

Coverstory ROAD ACCIDENTS

estimated loss of 1 per cent of the country's gross domestic product. According to the World Bank, developing countries lose approximately \$100 billion every year due to road crashes, which is twice the amount of all development aid provided by donors to developing countries.

Even scarier is the fact that road fatalities in India have been rising at the rate of 8 per cent a year and, paradoxically, have only increased even as massive amounts of money have been pumped into improving roads and adding new highways, flyovers and expressways. In India, it's a tragic conundrum; the better the road, the faster the traffic will go, but with lax enforcement, few rules and safety factors, it only leads to more deaths. One study showed that a 10 per cent increase in speed leads to a 30 per cent increase in road accident fatalities. Here's another shocking statistic: a leading cause of road deaths is drunk drivers but only between 2 and 8 per cent of cases involving drunken driving actually make it to court. Other factors that lead to the high incidence of road accidents: poor traffic management, bad roads, total lack of observance of traffic rules, no legal deterrents, corrupt traffic police, jaywalking pedestrians and a deadly mix of slow and fast-moving traffic, including the fact that a sizable

number of fatalities due to road accidents is avoidable for want of better road safety management and availability of prompt medical help.

In fact, the Global Status Report on Road Safety (GSRRS) by the World Health Organization says it is the low level of enforcement of simple road safety measures in India, like prohibition and monitoring of drunken driving, wearing of seat belts and child restraints, and checks on speeding, that leads to a majority of deaths. According to a study by a leading hospital in Delhi, merely enforcing sobriety checks and carrying out random breath-testing can bring down alcohol-related crashes by 20 per cent. Drunken driving accounts for 29 per cent of deaths involving motorised two-wheelers. Similarly, wearing a helmet can reduce the risk of death by 40 per cent, while wearing seat belts can reduce the fatality by 50 per cent for front seat passengers. The tragedy is that these basic road safety measures are either not followed or are blatantly violated in India. Says Kiran Bedi, who was named 'Crane Bedi' for her attempts to curb traffic violations while serving as traffic commissioner

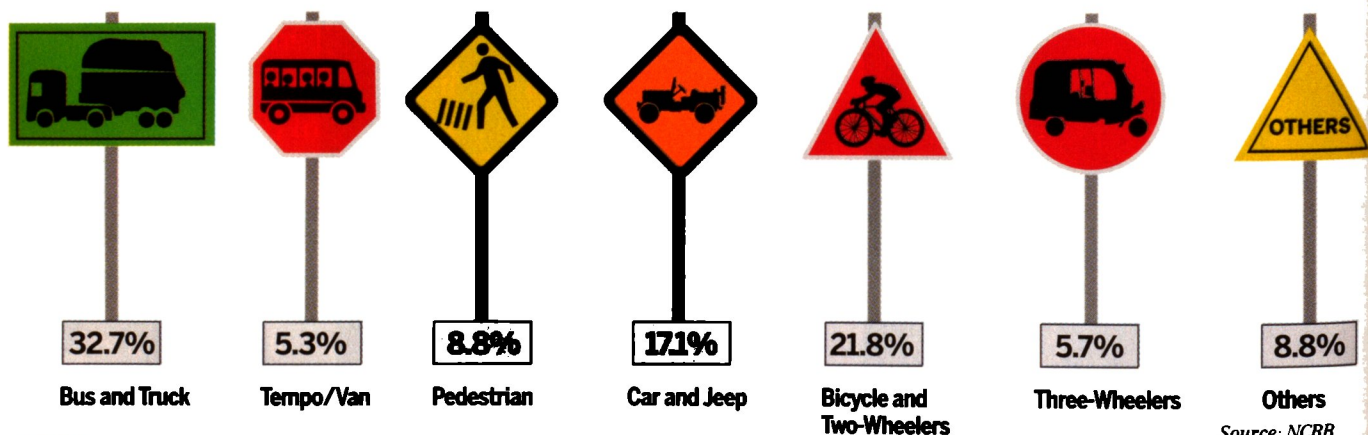
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PEDESTRIANS AND CYCLISTS FORM A MAJOR CHUNK OF CASUALTIES

USER UNFRIENDLY

Almost all kinds of road users kill or are killed on Indian roads



1

OUT OF EVERY 10 ROAD FATALITIES IN THE WORLD IS AN INDIAN, TAKING THE COUNTRY TO THE TOP OF THIS DUBIOUS CHART.